Welfare & Safeguarding Escalations Policy

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Review Cycle: Annual (June 2027) **Approved By:** Executive Committee / Vice-Chair

1. Introduction & Philosophy

At Kingswood United FC, safeguarding is everyone's responsibility. We are fully committed to creating a safe, inclusive, and enjoyable environment for all children, young people, and adults at risk. This policy defines our structured operational escalation pathway, ensuring that every reported welfare or safeguarding concern is dealt with robustly, transparently, and conclusively.

We strictly adhere to **The FA Safeguarding Framework**, incorporating proactive prevention, simplified report mechanics, and rapid, synchronized integration with county and statutory authorities. Furthermore, this policy embeds the **"Closing the Circle"** methodology, transforming casework from a linear protocol into a continuous loop of accountability where no case is abandoned or left un-remediated.

2. Intake & Immediate Action Gateway

Every safeguarding or welfare concern received must be funneled cleanly into the club's reporting infrastructure to ensure accurate oversight and triage.

2.1 Core Reception Channels

- **Digital Submission (Preferred):** All concerns should be recorded through the official Kingswood United Safeguarding Concern / Incident Report Google Form. Senders emailing the centralized inbox (welfare@kingswoodunited.co.uk) are auto-responded to with an immediate link directive to complete this form.
- **Manual or Verbal Reports:** If a welfare officer, coach, manager, or committee official receives a telephone call, message, or in-person disclosure, they must immediately signpost the reporter to the Google Form. If the reporter is unable or unwilling to complete it, the official must fill it out accurately on their behalf.

CRITICAL GATEWAY: IMMEDIATE RISK OR DANGER PROCEDURES

If a child or adult is in immediate physical danger, requires urgent medical attention, or a disclosure reveals an active, severe threat of harm, **bypass all internal club intake structures immediately**. Do not delay action by completing forms first.

1. Call the Emergency Services immediately at **999** (Police/Ambulance).
2. Optionally contact the **NSPCC Helpline** at **0808 800 5000** for immediate emergency guidance.
3. Once emergency safety is fully established, notify the Lead Welfare Officer and enter the incident into the Case Tracking system retrospectively.

3. Operational Structure & Ownership Matrix

Access to the welfare inbox and form submissions is strictly secured and restricted to the Lead Welfare Officer, designated Assistant Welfare Officers, and select Executive Committee members. To ensure rapid execution, operational ownership is distributed cleanly across specific age phases and club programmes:

Official Name	Role Title	Operational Matrix & Assignment Scope
Luke	Welfare Assistant	Age groups 3 to 6 years; Wildcats, Cubs, and Ballers programmes.
Alex	Lead Welfare Officer	Age groups U7s to U9s; Overall safeguarding leadership.
Becki	Welfare Assistant	Age groups U10s to U12s.
Emma	Welfare Assistant	Age groups U13 to U15.
Charlotte	Committee Member	Age groups 16+ and Open Age squads.
Tom	Vice-Chair	Strategic Alignment, Governance Oversight, and Committee Liaison.

4. The Safeguarding Circle: Continuous Case Management

To prevent cases from slipping through administrative cracks, Kingswood United FC enforces a mandatory 4-phase cyclic model driven by the centralized **Welfare Dashboard & Tracker Spreadsheet**. This replaces standard linear tracking and demands strict closeout validation.

> **The Continuous Loop Lifecycle**
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> Every case must cycle sequentially through all four phases before any closeout status can be authorized.

Phase 1: Record an Incident

Upon form receipt, the assigned officer according to the ownership matrix must immediately open the Welfare Tracker and establish a new row. The officer will assign a unique, sequential **Case Number**, log the baseline metrics (Format received, Setting, Individuals at Risk, and Allegation details), and declare the initial Triage Level:

- **LOW LEVEL (GREEN)** : Poor practice or low-level operational concerns. Handled locally within the club framework.
- **AMBER LEVEL** : Possible risk of harm or persistent poor practice patterns. Triggers mandatory consultation with the **East Riding County FA Designated Safeguarding Officer (DSO)**.
- **HIGH LEVEL (RED)** : Serious safeguarding breaches or active disclosures of abuse. Handled via immediate external referral to the County FA, Children's Social Care, or Police.

Phase 2: Record the Solution & Way Forward

The managing officer logs all investigation details, witness accounts, child/person voices, and mitigation paths. If the incident represents a systemic or recurring hazard to club culture, it must be cross-referenced on the **Risk Register** tab, mapping out a clear calculated risk score (Likelihood × Impact) and long-term control protocols.

Phase 3: Information Sharing & Communication Loop

No case may reside in isolation. The assigned owner is required to verify and check-off that communications have been conducted with all essential parties. This includes internal reporting (Chair, Vice-Chair, and relevant Committee updates on a strict need-to-know basis) and crucial external communication (notifying parents, carers, social workers, or the County FA DSO where legally and ethically appropriate).

Phase 4: CHECK... Have You Closed the Circle?

A case cannot be flagged as "Completed" or "Closed" simply because an intervention occurred. The Lead Welfare Officer (Alex) and the case owner must conduct a final validation check: *Are all records detailed? Is the solution fully implemented? Have the families or statutory parties been formally updated or signposted?* Only when the loop is structurally unified can the case status be finalized.

5. Confidentiality, Records, and Governance

All records are preserved with enterprise security within the limited-access Google Drive. No official is permitted to promise absolute confidentiality to an informant or victim; it must be clearly stated that information will be shared with the East Riding FA DSO or statutory services if it is necessary to secure a person's life or safety. Anonymized monthly trend data is extracted by Tom (Vice-Chair) to inform executive committee planning and ensure continuous club safety adjustment.